

The stolen goods would be handed over to an accomplice or thrown out of the window, to be retrieved later. Some carried locked bags filled with rags, bundles of clothes, or steel trunks to swap with passengers' luggage. Others cut jewellery from around their sleeping victims' necks or wrists, tickling their feet with a feather to get them to turn as needed. Usually, gangs would work a specific line until the police caught on, then moved on to other lines and towns. There were cases where passengers tried to resist or give chase. In such situations, there were horrific reports of skirmishes and travellers being thrown off trains or murdered.

Constant vigilance

Besides the watch and ward staff and recommendations for increased police presence and patrolling, the railway authorities adopted a number of measures to control rising crime. By 1921, most provinces had appointed police guards who travelled on the passenger trains.

The Eastern Bengal Railway installed a device that lit up the sides of the train if it reached a certain speed. Barred windows were introduced to prevent nimble thieves from reaching through open windows to make off with unattended coats and bags. The railway companies experimented with different kinds of locks and rivets to protect goods wagons. Compartments reserved for women had tower bolts on the inside of the doors. However, as the 1921 Simla Report of the Railway Police quoted a witness, "A flood of light is the best *chaukidar* [guard]."